
Knots

Learn these four and stop there

Four knots will cover everything in this guide

Every knot weakens the line it is tied in; a good knot simply weakens it less. Two habits matter more than which knot you choose: **wet it before you pull it tight**, because friction burns and permanently weakens monofilament, and **seat it slowly with steady pressure**, then look at it. A knot with a crossed wrap is a knot that will fail on the best fish of the day.

The four

Knot	Use it for	How to tie it
Improved clinch	Hook, swivel or lure to line. The everyday knot.	Pass the tag through the eye. Twist the tag around the standing line five to seven times. Pass the tag back through the small loop right at the eye, then <i>back through the large loop</i> you just created — that second pass is the “improved” part and it is what stops it slipping. Wet and pull the standing line slowly. Trim close.
Palomar	Braid to anything; the <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> . Stronger than a clinch and harder to tie wrong.	Double about six inches of line and pass the doubled loop through the eye. Tie a loose overhand knot with the doubled line, leaving the hook hanging. Pass the loop completely <i>over</i> the hook. Wet, then pull both the standing line and the tag to seat it. Trim.
Uni (grinner)	Leader to hook; and tied twice, back to back, it joins two lines of different diameter.	Pass the tag through the eye and lay it back alongside the standing line to form a loop. Wrap the tag through that loop and around both strands five or six times. Wet and pull the tag to close the coils, then slide the whole knot down to the eye.
Double surgeon’s	Joining leader to main line quickly, including with cold hands.	Lay the two lines alongside each other, overlapping by six inches. Treating them as one, tie a simple overhand knot, then pass the same ends through a second time. Wet, and pull all four ends at once. Trim both tags.

Getting them right

Wet every knot	Saliva or water, every time, before the final pull. A dry-cinched mono knot can lose a third of its strength to friction heat and you will never see the damage.
Pull the right end	On a clinch and a Palomar, seat the knot by pulling the <i>standing line</i> steadily — not by yanking the tag.
Leave a short tag	About 1/8 inch. Cutting flush lets the tag pull back through under load; leaving half an inch collects weed.
Look at it	Coils should lie in a neat barrel with no crossovers. If it looks wrong it is wrong. Cut it off and tie it again — it takes twenty seconds.
Retie often	After every fish over a couple of pounds, after any snag, and after fishing rock. Run the last two feet of line between your fingers: if you feel roughness, cut it back and retie.
Braid is different	Braid is slippery. Use a Palomar, or add extra wraps to a uni. A standard clinch in braid will slip.

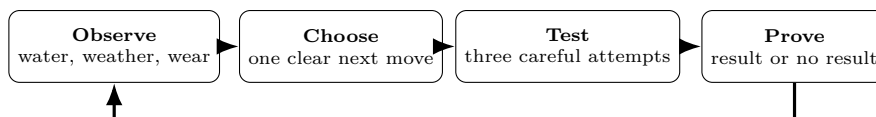
Two things that are not knots

Snap swivel	A fast way to change lures, and it lets a lure swing freely. But it is one more failure point and it is visible — so on Pine Lake’s clear water, tie direct.
Wire leader	Not optional for pike, <i>see the Northern Pike sheet</i> . Most are pre-made with a swivel and snap. If you tie your own, use a haywire twist rather than trying to knot single-strand wire.

Teaching these

Practise on rope or paracord first, at a size a child can see, before touching 6 lb monofilament on a windy dock. Learn the improved clinch until it can be tied without looking, then the Palomar. Those two alone will cover everything on every rig sheet in this guide.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
What am I testing?	Change one variable only and state what success will look like before the attempt.	Restore the last known setup; avoid changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
Is the system sound?	Trace the full chain from hand to fish: line, knot, leader, hook, drag, handling tool, route home.	Stop on any rough line, crossed wrap, open snap, dull point, missing tool, or unsafe condition; repair or leave.
What proves completion?	A repeatable result and a final tactile/visual check, not merely finishing the written steps.	Repeat slowly under good light. If the check is ambiguous, treat it as a failure.

Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish condition makes that route doubtful, change the plan before casting.

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